

width layouts often are designed to accommodate a specific screen resolution and can have too much white space when viewed on monitors that are larger, or with resolution that is higher, than specified. However, they are usually easier to design because dimensions and expectations are determined before the design starts and there is much less room for unknowns. A good example of a fixed-width web site design is the BBC news site at <http://bbc.co.uk>. As the browser window is resized, the elements of the layout don't change, even when the browser window width is smaller than the overall width of the page.

On the other hand, fluid-width sites adapt to the browser window and scale accordingly. These layouts, while popular, can be difficult to achieve when imagery is part of the structure. Fluidwidth sites are often good for content-rich sites but introduce a lot of nuances to the design process.

Different browsers render differently and fluid-width layouts make it difficult to completely address all types of user choices and preferences. Engadget (<http://engadget.com>), the popular gadget blog from AOL, employs a fluid-width layout. While certain elements are constricted to a minimum width, creating some fixed-width behavior at lower resolutions, when the browser is resized, many of the page elements are flexible.

Sidebars

Most WordPress themes (and blogs in general) have sidebars. Depending on your site, you might want a single sidebar or more than one. You can even go with no sidebars. (Often, sites without sidebars have “normal” sidebar elements as part of their footers.)

Sidebars are often used to display ads, recent posts, recent comments, popular posts, or information from other social networks such as Flickr or Twitter. Because most themes are built to be able to use widgets, it is easy to configure or reconfigure them.

4.2 Finding and Implementing Free Themes

WordPress themes are the other side of WordPress extensibility. In Part II of this book, I took a long, hard look at plugins, hooks, widgets, and other aspects of extending WordPress with plugins. The other side of that equation is themes. As with plugins, WordPress has an entire theme infrastructure available for theme developers to use. The theme application programming interface (API) is comprised of an abundance of template tags and, as with plugins, themes can be installed with one click from inside the WordPress